

Keeping the Ex-Enemy Close but Not in My Backyard: Community Receptivity to the Reintegration of Deradicalized Terrorists in Nigeria

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ABSTRACT

How receptive are societies to the reintegration of deradicalized terrorists? Specifically in countries where the terrorists attacked the communities targeted for reintegration. I posit that closer proximity to terrorist violence is correlated with lower receptivity to reintegration in such scenarios. I examine the disposition of Nigerian citizens toward the Government's deradicalization and reintegration program. I delineate three community categories: Core, Outer, and Peripheral based on their proximity to incidents of terrorist violence. Employing semi-structured interviews with 100 Nigerians across these communities, the empirical findings contradict my initial arguments. Surprisingly, the community closest to terrorist violence exhibited the highest receptivity to reintegration. Furthermore, community residents' proximity to designated reintegration venues was negatively correlated with receptivity towards reintegration.

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They should not come near me; they should stay where they are. I don't even understand why the government is helping these people; they killed people

-Lagos Interviewee

In 2019, after the US coalition forces took control of the last Islamic State in Iraq and Syria (ISIS) stronghold in Syria, numerous ISIS fighters surrendered, forcing several nations to grapple with the predicament of repatriating and reintegrating their citizens who had joined the terrorist group. In the United States, the story of Hoda Muthana, an American woman who snuck into Syria to join ISIS in 2014, ignited a fervent ethical debate, touching on issues such as citizenship, deradicalization, reintegration, forgiveness, repentance, ideology, and religion.¹ These debates exposed citizens' broader concerns over reintegrating individuals who embraced extremist ideologies, specifically, potential security risks associated with their return and the truthfulness of their repentance.

The rapid rise of transnational terrorism has led to a surge in foreign fighters participating in conflicts beyond their home countries, from Syria to Yemen.² Consequently, many nations have devised deradicalization and quasi-deradicalization programs to address the challenge of reintegrating their citizens who have joined

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terrorist groups.³ However, these efforts primarily focus on concerns related to national security, leaving unanswered questions about how communities perceive the deradicalization and reintegration of former terrorists into their communities who were members of the terrorist groups that victimized their society. How would the issues raised by Ms. Muthana's return have been different if she had participated in terrorist activities within the United States?

In Indonesia, the terrorist group Jemaah Islamiyah (JI) has conducted attacks since the early 2000s, primarily targeting Western interests, leading to significant loss of life, mostly of foreigners, with Indonesian civilians as collateral damage.⁴ The Indonesian government established a deradicalization program following the 2002 Bali Bombing that killed over 200 civilians, aiming to rehabilitate over 170 captured and imprisoned members of JI.⁵ The program's success remains unclear, with a lack of monitoring and recidivism data, corruption, and perceived justice complicating the assessment of its effectiveness.⁶ Over 100 former JI members have been reintegrated into the community with expected pushback from the communities and families of victims of JI's attacks. However, because JI's attacks focused on hotels and businesses targeting foreign interests, reintegrating these individuals into the community does not raise questions about the potential stumbling blocks to returning terrorists to the communities they destroyed.

Jama'atu Ahlis Sunna Lidda'awati wal-Jihad (JAS), internationally known as Boko Haram (BH), began its insurgency in Nigeria in July 2009, when it conducted a five-state uprising that led to the death of several members, the capture of its leader Mohammed Yusuf, and his subsequent extrajudicial killing in police custody.⁷ Yusuf's death catalyzed the insurgency that BH has waged for over a decade in Nigeria, aimed at limiting Western education and influence and establishing an Islamic state in Nigeria.⁸

During its violent campaign, BH formed and dissolved alliances with Al-Qaeda and later ISIS, which increased its lethality but weakened its cohesion.⁹ These alliances and their subsequent dissolution splintered BH into two factions: JAS members loyal to the original BH and the Islamic State West Africa Province (ISWAP), members loyal to the Islamic State (IS).¹⁰ BH and ISWAP have experienced significant leadership decapitation, weakening their capacities but not hindering their competition for dominance in Northern Nigeria, Chad, and Mali.¹¹ BH has wreaked havoc on the region, conducting attacks that have killed over 350,000 people and displaced over 3 million.¹²

In 2016, the Nigerian government started its deradicalization and reintegration program named Operation Safe Corridor (OPSC) after it announced it would grant immunity to anyone who surrendered who previously or was currently a BH member.¹³ However, the first group of participants in the OPSC camp in Gombe State enrolled in 2019. Initially, the program operated clandestinely, leading to mistrust and apprehension among citizens that, today, still overshadow the program's reputation. The government has been reintegrating these individuals into communities in Northern Nigeria, the region most affected by BH's destructive attacks, where the victims' families, survivors, internally displaced individuals, and community members reside, raising questions about the acceptance of these individuals.

However, with Nigeria's geography and governmental capacity, all other regions in Nigeria that have experienced BH attacks either directly or indirectly through the media also register concerns about the reintegration process. The Nigerian government's endeavor to deradicalize and subsequently reintegrate these ex-BH fighters into

communities in Northern Nigeria ravaged by BH's attacks provides the impeccable opportunity to examine the research inquiries at hand. To what extent do societies exhibit receptivity towards the reintegration of deradicalized terrorists into their communities, particularly when these reintegrating individuals were formerly affiliated with terrorist groups responsible for perpetrating acts of violence against their own families, neighbors, and fellow citizens?

I posit that the proximity of community members to instances of terrorist violence exerts a discernible influence on their predisposition to accept the reintegration of deradicalized terrorists into their midst. Consequently, this study meticulously examines the nuances of community receptivity across three distinct categories: communities directly exposed to terrorist violence, those in immediate proximity, and communities situated at a considerable distance from such violence within the same nation. My prior assumption is that the receptivity to reintegration efforts will be least favorable in communities closest to terrorist violence. Paradoxically, the research revealed that communities with the highest experience of direct terrorist violence were more willing to receive ex-terrorists than communities with no experience of direct terrorist violence.

Within the domain of political science research, there is a notable dearth of comprehensive investigations focused on understanding community receptivity to reintegration, particularly within the delineated parameters of proximity to terrorist violence. This project, therefore, assumes a pivotal role in bridging this conspicuous research void. The counterintuitive finding of higher receptivity to reintegration in the community that has experienced the most terrorist violence offers a substantive contribution to the existing body of knowledge in this domain. First, I review deradicalization and reintegration, briefly examining the context of deradicalization and reintegration in Nigeria. I discuss the significance of community receptivity as an indispensable determinant of the overall efficacy of deradicalization and reintegration programs.

Subsequently, I outline my arguments, explicitly focusing on the pivotal element of proximity to violence and its influence on the receptivity to the reintegrating deradicalized terrorists. Within this context, I outline three distinct community categories: Core, Outer, and Peripheral, dependent on their proximity to incidents of terrorist violence. Next, I provide an overview of the qualitative research method I employed in this study, specifically 20–45-min-long semi-structured interviews of 100 respondents across communities conducted from January to May 2022. Lastly, the paper culminates in an extensive discussion of three in-depth interviews, one from each community category. These interviews serve as a vehicle to explore the nuances underpinning community receptivity across each community and how the empirical findings have recalibrated and refined my initially posited assumptions.

Deradicalization and Reintegration

Deradicalization programs are designed to rehabilitate individuals involved in extremist activities by addressing ideological, social, and economic factors that contribute to radicalization through a variety of programs, including psychological counseling, religious re-education, and vocational training, to reintegrate participants into society.¹⁴ Deradicalization programs are an offshoot of disarmament, demobilization, and

reintegration (DDR) programs. DDR programs are long-term security and peacebuilding initiatives employed to disarm, demobilize, and reintegrate former combatants into their society after the cessation of protracted conflict with the government in mainly developing countries.¹⁵

Utilizing DDR programs as a foundational model for deradicalization initiatives acknowledges that combatant groups often employ terrorist tactics during their violent campaigns against the nation and the communities they ultimately reintegrate into through DDR efforts. However, combatants' engagement in violent conflicts is typically motivated by opportunistic factors. Consequently, countries emphasize providing economic reintegration measures, such as job opportunities and skill development, to the returning combatants within the framework of the DDR model to eliminate the fundamental motivation for a return to violence.¹⁶

Deradicalization programs are a multifaceted endeavor that must simultaneously achieve several key objectives. One of its primary tasks is identifying the motivations driving former terrorists, whether from ideological convictions or transactional factors while assessing the potential for successful reintegration into society should the program prove effective.¹⁷ Furthermore, the program must employ appropriate interventions aimed at dissuading individuals from returning to terrorism and addressing the fundamental beliefs that initially led to their involvement in such activities.¹⁸ This aspect underscores the inadequacy of traditional DDR processes in addressing the fundamental objective of deradicalization, which is eradicating the underlying ideology motivating their participation to prevent re-engagement.

In a nation dealing with domestic terrorists, the primary concern is not the potential of a return to violence due to the presence of weapons but rather the enduring radical ideologies that these former terrorists may still espouse. It is plausible for a former terrorist to reintegrate into the community without possessing weapons, lead a peaceful life for an extended period, and revert to violence driven by their ideological convictions. This motivates countries to prioritize deradicalization efforts to eradicate the underlying dangerous ideology. Horgan questioned the effectiveness of deradicalization programs in removing these ideological strongholds and instead argued that these programs work to reduce re-engagement in violence.¹⁹ Although the stated goal is removing extremist ideology, none of the existing programs can prove that they have achieved it.

In response to escalating terrorist attacks, the burgeoning population of BH fighters in custody, and a failing prison system, Nigeria turned to deradicalization and reintegration to address these pressing issues. The government has dedicated resources to ensure former combatants are comfortable throughout the deradicalization process and to encourage current members of BH to surrender and join the program. However, this has fueled reports of prisoners protesting the perceived preferential treatment BH prisoners receive and internally displaced people condemning the government for not investing similar resources in rebuilding their community.²⁰

Most deradicalization research focuses on the types of deradicalization programs, the examination of questionable ethical practices, the lack of international standards for measuring success, and recidivism rates.²¹ Consequently, there is little deradicalization research about how community support for the reintegration of deradicalized terrorists affects the success of reintegration and recidivism rates. Criminology research

on the reintegration of criminals has found that community support and acceptance are significant predictors of recidivism amongst reintegrated criminals because time with family reduces the opportunities to seek out crime, and community acceptance can help offenders with jobs and feelings of belonging.²²

Community and Reintegration

Existing criminology research findings that community support is vital to reintegration success can inform exploration into community support for the reintegration of deradicalized terrorists. However, these studies cannot directly speak to receptivity in communities affected by terrorism because the trauma associated with terrorism is significantly higher than the trauma from criminal offenses. A few terrorism researchers have examined community support for the reintegration of deradicalized former terrorists in Nigeria. Early researchers exploring the community's receptivity to reintegration in Nigeria focused on either interviewing community members in Northern Nigeria, where reintegration occurs, or in communities far removed from Northeast Nigeria.²³

Owonikoko improved the research on receptivity to reintegration in Nigeria by conducting 21 interviews and administering 235 surveys in 3 states, Borno, Yobe, and Adamawa, focusing on the citizens' experience with terrorism in the first half and their receptivity to reintegration in the second half of the survey.²⁴ They found that community members are unreceptive to the reintegration of ex-BH fighters because they believe the government is prioritizing ex-BH fighters over victims, and they doubt the truthfulness of the deradicalized individuals' repentance.²⁵ I argue that the survey's focus on the respondents' experience with terrorism in the first half unintentionally primed their negative receptivity to the reintegration process. While the respondents are unlikely to forget their experiences, prompting them to remember these experiences before asking about reintegration increases the likelihood of visceral refusal to the prospect of reintegration.

Ike et al. further advanced research into community receptivity to reintegration by examining the correlation between the level of education and the likelihood of accepting ex-offenders into society through a mixed method research that surveyed 1187 participants on the Public Attitude towards Ex-Offenders and their Reintegration (PAER) scale.²⁶ They found no correlation between education and the likelihood of accepting the reintegration of ex-offenders and, using thematic analysis of the open-form question, identified lack of trust and past trauma as reasons for respondents' lack of receptivity to the reintegration.²⁷ Unfortunately, Ike et al.'s work cannot speak to the community's receptivity to reintegration for ex-BH fighters because it focused on ex-offenders, which included Niger-delta militants and regular criminals. Additionally, the PAER scale questions focused on general statements about attitudes towards ex-offenders instead of questions about their reintegration and how community members would feel about this process, so it fails to adequately speak to their receptivity to reintegration.

Godefroidt and Langer's pivotal research created a conjoint experiment to examine community receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized terrorists based on three distinct hypotheses.²⁸ The first hypothesis pertained to the receptivity of citizens when

the individual had been coerced into joining BH, the second focused on their receptivity when the individual had committed less egregious acts during their affiliation with the group, and the third hypothesis explored their receptivity when the individual voluntarily disengaged from BH.²⁹ Drawing responses from a sample of 2,000 former university students in Nigeria, their findings reveal that respondents exhibited greater receptivity towards the reintegration of deradicalized individuals who had been compelled to join the group and subsequently expressed remorse for their actions.³⁰ In contrast, respondents displayed reduced receptivity towards individuals with a more militant history of atrocities and those who exhibited lesser degrees of contrition.³¹

However, it is essential to acknowledge certain limitations Godefroidt and Langer recognized in their research. Northeast Nigeria, acutely impacted by BH's attacks and the venue for reintegration, will likely exhibit substantially different receptivity compared to respondents from other regions in Nigeria. Consequently, the underrepresentation of respondents from the Northeast region of Nigeria within the sample population raises potential concerns regarding the generalizability and validity of the study's findings. Additionally, the skewed demographic characteristics of the respondent population, characterized by youth and elevated educational levels, necessitate caution when extrapolating the results to a broader demographic spectrum.³²

These pioneering projects, although constituting substantial contributions to our comprehension of community receptivity in Nigeria and attitudes toward various categories of reintegrating offenders, offer an incomplete picture regarding community receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters in Nigeria. Specifically, none of them ask about the receptivity to deradicalized ex-BH fighters across regions and socioeconomic classes in Nigeria. Consequently, there remains a gap in the literature regarding the nuanced relationship between community receptivity and proximity to violence, specifically, the influence of proximity to violence on such receptivity.

Proximity and Receptivity

I argue that proximity to terrorist violence exerts a discernible influence on the opinions and actions of community members. Specifically, I posit that closer community proximity to terrorist violence correlates with less receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized terrorists. Receptivity, in this study, is defined as the willingness or capacity of a community to embrace and accommodate the process of reintegrating deradicalized terrorists into their community and broader society. Criminology research informed by Not in My Backyard (NIMBY) literature and Transitional Justice research provide a solid foundation to explore the relationship between proximity and receptivity to reintegration.

NIMBY literature predominately examines the public perception of or opposition to various undesirable government land use projects, such as nuclear waste sites, asylums, and public waste sites.³³ Dear found that community opposition stemmed from concerns about property values, personal security, and neighborhood amenities.³⁴ Criminology research on public support for criminal reintegration has traditionally focused on understanding what demographic and political attributes influence support for reintegration policies.³⁵ However, a few criminology studies drawing on NIMBY literature have explored the relationship between proximity and community receptivity.

Socia et al. surveyed 773 respondents to identify public support for emergency housing policies for sex offenders in four scenarios: no cost, increased taxes, in my backyard (IMBY), and not in my backyard (NIMBY).³⁶ They found no significant support for any scenario but more support for the no-cost scenario compared to the increased tax scenario.³⁷ Socia et al. also reported no significant difference between IMBY and NIMBY scenarios; instead, they found indifference or neutrality among respondents, which they argue contributes to the increased enactment of NIMBY policies with little public opposition.³⁸

Garland et al. surveyed 1000 randomly selected Missouri residents to understand their receptivity to transitional housing (TH) in their city and neighborhood in four scenarios: overall support, support for transitional housing for violent offenders, sex offenders, and drug offenders.³⁹ Respondents expressed 54% support for TH in their city and 29% support for TH in their neighborhood. However, only 24% expressed support for TH for sex and violent offenders in their city, and 10% expressed support for TH for sex and violent offenders in their neighborhood.⁴⁰ Support for TH for drug offenders was higher, with 35% expressing support for TH in their city and 19% in their neighborhood.⁴¹

These groundbreaking findings can illuminate this project's examination of community receptivity to the reintegration of ex-BH fighters, specifically, into their state or neighborhood. However, they do not directly address the question, as they focus on criminal offenders rather than terrorists, and the respondents are not direct victims of violence. Transitional justice research examines the consequences, effectiveness, and effects of peacebuilding and reintegration initiatives after genocide or protracted mass violence.⁴² While this research has primarily focused on how countries design and implement retributive (trials, incarceration) and restorative justice (amnesty, compensation to victims) initiatives, a few studies have explored victims' support for these measures.

Pham et al. conducted surveys of 2,585 residents in northern Uganda to examine, among other things, the opinions of victims and non-victims on several transitional justice mechanisms, including trials, truth commissions, and reparations.⁴³ They found that respondents with direct exposure to violence supported amnesty more than those with no exposure to violence, and respondents from districts with less exposure to violence supported accountability measures more than those from direct violence victim districts.⁴⁴ In contrast, Nussio et al., in a survey of 1,843 Columbians, of which 315 were direct victims of violence, found no significant differences between the opinions of victims and non-victims about different transitional justice measures.⁴⁵

Hall et al. examined victims' attitudes toward transitional justice measures by surveying 1,007 respondents in Bosnia.⁴⁶ They argued that past experiences of wartime violence and present-day social interdependence with perpetrators impact transitional justice preferences.⁴⁷ Hall et al. found that exposure to violence was associated with support for retributive justice measures, while social interdependence was associated with support for restorative measures.⁴⁸ Additionally, they found that respondents who remained displaced from their homes were less likely to support amnesty compared to those who had returned to their pre-war homes. They argue that returnees' social interdependence with the perpetrators predisposes them to favor forgiveness.

As stated above, genocide, interstate wartime violence, and the resulting DDR initiative cannot speak directly to terrorism-related conflict due to the ideological motivations for terrorism and the extensive societal victimization beyond the direct victims. Additionally, the conflicts in Uganda, Columbia, and Bosnia involved inter-group violence, State participation, and genocidal actions perpetrated by neighbors, complicating the victims' ability to hold perpetrators accountable, especially when the perpetrator is the State. Furthermore, these researchers interviewed victims years after conflict cessation and over eight years into the implementation of transitional justice mechanisms in these countries. Consequently, these respondents had the opportunity to rebuild their lives and heal from the violence they experienced, predisposing them to want to forgive the perpetrators and leave their victimization in the past.

Therefore, these projects cannot speak to proximity to violence and receptivity in Nigeria because the conflict is ongoing, they didn't examine proximity, and the perpetrators are terrorists who victimize citizens regardless of their ethnicity or affiliations. A few terrorism studies have investigated the influence of proximity to terrorism and its impact on public opinion about terrorism; however, none have discussed the effects of proximity on receptivity to reintegration.⁴⁹ Research investigating voting behavior across communities at varying distances from terrorist attacks provides empirical support for the argument that proximity to terrorist violence influences public opinion.⁵⁰

Getmansky and Zeitzoff examined voting patterns in localities within and beyond the range of terrorist rocket attacks within Israel. They revealed significant disparities in voting behavior between localities falling within the range of rocket attacks and those situated outside this range.⁵¹ Notably, localities near rocket attacks exhibited a voting preference that leaned more toward right-wing political candidates because of the perception that right-wing candidates were likelier to adopt resolute stances on crime and security, resulting in a 2–6% increase in right-wing voting compared to localities outside the range.⁵²

I posit that terrorist attacks, engineered to instill fear and garner widespread attention, should theoretically evoke resistance to deradicalization and rehabilitation efforts throughout the country because citizens inevitably witness acts of violence in varying degrees and forms. However, I contend that the community's receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized terrorists will reduce significantly the closer the community's proximity to instances of terrorist violence. Consequently, I define the communities as Core, Outer, and Peripheral, dependent on their proximity to incidents of terrorist violence (Figure 1).

Outer Community: Outer communities are situated at a considerable geographic distance (over 500 km) from the epicenter of terrorist violence and primarily encounter such violence through indirect means, notably *via* media reporting of these incidents. Their trauma stems from this vicarious exposure, their physical distance from the Core community, and the fear of potential future attacks. Simultaneously, they express gratitude for their fortune in having remained unscathed thus far and grieve the loss of fellow citizens within the Core community.

I posit that this geographical distance significantly influences the receptivity of Outer community members toward the reintegration of deradicalized terrorists. Specifically, the Outer community will exhibit more receptivity toward reintegrating

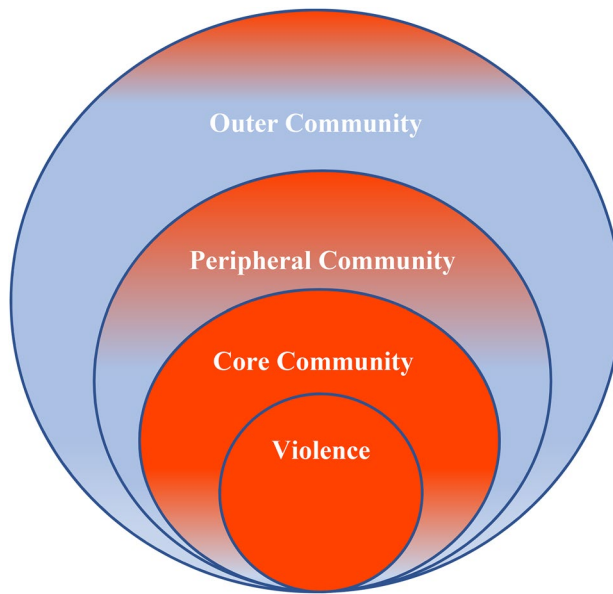


Figure 1. Representation of community proximity.

these ex-BH fighters into Nigeria than the Peripheral and Core communities. This heightened receptivity is predicated on the belief that the reintegration would help maintain their distance from terrorist violence, thereby mitigating security concerns. Furthermore, they do not exhibit an elevated level of trauma or a heightened sense of injustice in response to the prospect of reintegration—a response one might anticipate within the Core community, which informs their heightened degree of receptivity.

Peripheral Community: In contrast, Peripheral communities are positioned in immediate proximity (within 200–300 km) from the focal point of terrorist violence, resulting in their exposure to such violence both directly, albeit occasionally, and indirectly through media coverage. What distinguishes the Peripheral community is their heightened personal affiliations with Core community members, fostered over the years through extended family ties, friendships, and communal relationships. These ties, combined with their direct victimization and witnessing the attacks' impacts on Core community neighbors, heighten the Peripheral community trauma compared to the Outer community. The Peripheral community has experienced a notable respite from violence due to intensified counterterrorism efforts or shifts in terrorist tactics.

I theorize that the Peripheral community will exhibit lower receptivity to reintegrating deradicalized ex-BH fighters into Nigeria compared to the Outer community but higher receptivity than the Core communities. This decreased receptivity within the Peripheral community stems from heightened trauma, perceived injustice, and the reduced geographical buffer separating them from the epicenter of violence. Consequently, this amplifies fears of reintegrated individuals returning to violence, thus posing a more immediate threat to the Peripheral community compared to the Outer community.

Core Community: Core community members are situated (within 0–200 km) from terrorist violence. Core communities have endured an unrelenting barrage of terrorist

violence, resulting in widespread personal victimization at the hands of these extremist groups. These relentless assaults devastate livelihoods and claim numerous lives, causing profound trauma linked to direct experiences of violence. Despite counterterrorism efforts reducing attack frequency, the total eradication of violence remains elusive. Furthermore, unlike the Outer community, Core community residents lack a geographical buffer to shield them from immediate threats.

I postulate that, due to unaddressed devastation and profound trauma, the Core community will exhibit the lowest receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters compared to the Peripheral and Outer Communities. This diminished receptivity stems from normative concerns about injustice and recidivism. The enduring presence of active terrorist groups perpetuates feelings of injustice, with deradicalized individuals seen as evading deserved punishment. Additionally, Core community members grapple with concerns about the potential for these individuals to rejoin terrorist groups and inflict further harm.

Criminology NIMBY research suggests that community members' unreceptivity to reintegration increases as the venue for reintegration grows closer to their domicile. The reduced support respondents expressed for transitional facilities for violent offenders in their state or neighborhoods in Garland et al.'s study supports my arguments for the Outer and Peripheral communities.⁵³ Additionally, transitional justice literature indicates that victims would support more retributive measures for perpetrators but may lean toward amnesty if they have rebuilt their lives or returned to their homes. Consequently, the continued displacement and terrorist attacks in Northeast Nigeria make support for retributive measures more likely, thereby supporting my arguments for the Core and Peripheral communities.

As criminology research establishes, the degree to which a community welcomes and accepts deradicalized individuals plays a pivotal role in determining the success of reintegration programs and reducing the potential for recidivism. Therefore, gaining insights into the receptivity of these communities, particularly concerning how proximity to violence influences their attitudes, becomes essential. No terrorism literature has explored the question of proximity to terrorist violence and its impact on receptivity to reintegration. This project bridges this lacuna.

Research Design

This project employed a qualitative research method approach to data collection and analysis, specifically judgment sampling. Judgment sampling, also called purposeful sampling, is a research methodology in which the researcher consciously and deliberately selects a sample based on a prior theoretical understanding of the issue deemed most suitable and relevant for addressing the specific research question.⁵⁴ Within the framework of this project, I selected respondents based on their socioeconomic class and community membership, and I allocated ten interviews per socioeconomic class, resulting in 30 interviews for each community. While judgment sampling allows researchers to explore the research question with an informed approach, it does not eliminate sampling bias, which is a significant concern with qualitative research methods.⁵⁵ To reduce sample bias in my research, I varied the location for my interviews; I went to local markets, neighborhoods, social clubs, and shopping malls.

The case selection for the communities was based on their geographical distance from the epicenter of violence. I utilized the Global Terrorism Database (GTD) to identify communities with the most terrorist attacks and Google Maps to pinpoint those at the appropriate distances.⁵⁶ Core communities experienced significant violence and are in immediate proximity to terrorist activity. Outer communities are located far from the Core community, ensuring they have never experienced a terrorist attack. Peripheral communities, historically subjected to direct terrorist attacks, are situated just outside the Core community.

For this project, I selected Lagos, Lagos State; Abuja, Federal Capital Territory; and Maiduguri, Borno State, as the Outer, Peripheral, and Core communities, respectively (Table 1). These urban centers provide the best opportunity to recruit respondents across all income levels, which would be challenging in rural areas. Maiduguri, with its proximity to BH's camp in Sambisa Forest, has experienced more terrorist attacks than any other city in Northeast Nigeria and has reintegrated a significant number of ex-BH fighters, making it the ideal Core community.⁵⁷

Table 1. Table of variation amongst communities.⁵⁹

Community	City, State	City population	State GDP per capita: (\$)	City terrorist attacks: 2020
Core Community	Maiduguri, Borno	803,000	\$785	45
Peripheral Community	Abuja, Federal Capital	3,278,000	\$1,292	2
Outer Community	Lagos, Lagos	14,368,000	\$2,174	0



Figure 2. Map of Nigeria.⁶⁰ Core, Peripheral, and Outer Communities are indicated with Purple Dots.

I selected Abuja, Federal Capital Territory, as the Peripheral community due to its historical exposure to terrorist attacks and its shared border with Kaduna State, which has also experienced significant terrorist activity. As Nigeria's former capital, Lagos still functions as Nigeria's economic, entertainment, and social center.⁵⁸ With its geographical distance from the Core community, Lagos represents the most suitable Outer community. These communities offer significant variation in economic development, culture, and urbanization, enhancing the generalizability of the findings to Nigeria (Figure 2).

I received approval (no. 4821) from the University of Virginia Institutional Review Board (IRB) to conduct fieldwork in Nigeria. I employed semi-structured interviews with 100 respondents, with 35 respondents in Lagos, 33 in Abuja, and 32 in Maiduguri, and conducted interviews in five languages: English, Pidgin English, Yoruba, Hausa, and Kanuri. I conducted interviews in Lagos and Abuja in person in English, Pidgin English, and Yoruba. However, due to security concerns, I conducted interviews in Maiduguri *via* Zoom and WhatsApp with the help of my translator to recruit and conduct interviews. The translator helped with ten interviews in Maiduguri and two in Abuja because I do not speak Hausa or Kanuri.

Table 2. Demographical breakdown of respondents.

Demographics	Categories	Overall	Outer Community	Peripheral Community	Core Community
Total		100	35	33	32
Gender	Male	69	18	25	26
	Female	31	17	8	6
Income Range	Low – N15,000–N69,999	25	9	6	10
	Low – N70,000–N149,999	10	3	5	2
	Middle – N150,000–N799,999	27	11	7	9
	Middle – N800,000–N1,499,999	6	1	4	1
	Upper – N1,500,000–N2,299,999	26	9	8	9
	Upper – N2,300,000 and above	6	2	3	1
Age Range	18–24	6	1	1	4
	25–34	31	10	15	6
	35–44	37	8	9	20
	45–54	8	5	2	1
	55–64	6	3	2	1
	65–Above	12	8	4	0
Employment Status	Employed full time	50	18	15	17
	Housewife	3	0	0	3
	Retired	7	6	1	0
	Student	1	0	0	1
Marital Status	Entrepreneur	39	11	17	11
	Never been married	34	9	16	9
	Married	62	23	16	23
	Divorced/Separated	4	3	1	0
Religion	Christian	49	27	19	3
	Muslim	48	7	12	29
	Traditional Religion	1	1	0	0
	None	1	0	1	0
	Other	1	0	1	0
Highest Education Level	No Formal Education	2	0	0	2
	Primary school graduate	7	4	0	3
	Secondary school graduate	11	5	4	2
	Some university	1	0	1	0
	2-year degree/OND/HND	9	1	2	6
	4-year degree/University/BSC	29	10	12	7
	Professional degree/B. L/MD	7	5	1	1
	Master's degree	28	10	8	10
	Doctorate	6	0	5	1

All respondents gave informed consent to the interview and its recording. I stressed the anonymity of the interview responses and informed each participant that they could stop the interview at any time or choose not to answer specific questions. The participants encompassed a diverse range of demographics, including variations in age, religion, and gender, as illustrated in Table 2. However, it is noteworthy that a higher proportion of upper-income participants were male, primarily because interviews within this demographic were conducted at exclusive social clubs and through contacts established during interviews with other upper-income respondents. Consequently, the survey population is male-dominated (Table 2).

During the research, I delineated the questions regarding receptivity into two categories: receptivity to reintegration into Nigeria and Northern Nigeria and respondents' state or neighborhood for Outer and Peripheral communities. For the Core communities, I divided receptivity into receptivity to reintegration into Nigeria and other states in Nigeria, such as Abuja and Lagos, and the respondents' state or neighborhood. I coded community receptivity into three categories: Not, Somewhat, and Very Receptive, using Dedoose analytical software.

Not receptive encapsulated respondents who clearly expressed no receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters or expressed reception because they could not say no to the government but would not accept it if it was not forced on them. Somewhat receptive captured respondents who agreed to the reintegration only if certain conditions were present or expressed acceptance because they believe it is the only solution to end the crisis because these deradicalized ex-BH fighters are Nigerians and cannot be reintegrated outside of Nigeria. Very receptive captured respondents who consciously stated high receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters based on several reasons, including religion, forgiveness, and hope that the reintegration causes the violence to end.

Results

Although respondents across all income levels answered the same questions and provided eye-opening insights into receptivity in their communities, I introduce three middle-income respondents, one from the Outer, Peripheral, and Core communities, in this section. Middle-income respondents consistently provided in-depth conversations and responses during the interviews, making them ideal subjects for exploring overall attitudes towards the reintegration of deradicalized former BH fighters in Nigeria. To maintain confidentiality, I assigned the pseudonyms Bola, Julia, and Ahmed to these respondents, whose responses will be discussed below.

Receptivity into Nigeria, Northern Nigeria, and Other States

In contrast to my prior arguments, the Outer community exhibited the lowest receptivity to reintegrating deradicalized ex-BH fighters into Nigeria and Northern Nigeria compared to the Peripheral communities. A significant 69% of respondents indicated they were not receptive to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters into Nigeria (Figure 3). While 58% of respondents indicated they were not receptive to their reintegration into Northern Nigeria (Figure 5). Interestingly, the respondents who changed their receptivity between Nigeria and Northern Nigeria indicated they were receptive

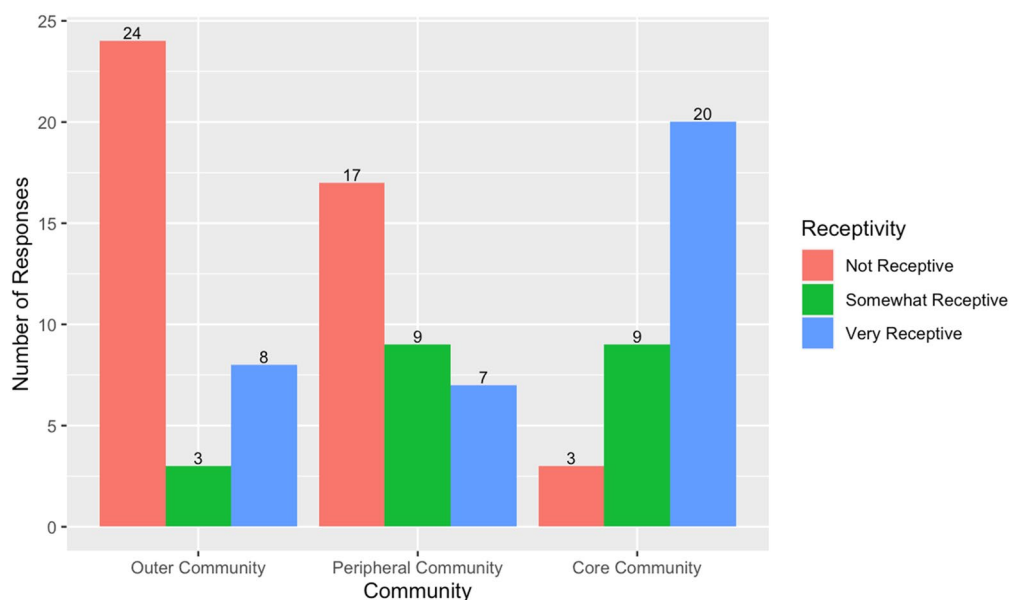


Figure 3. Receptivity to reintegration into Nigeria by community.

to reintegration in the North because the deradicalized ex-BH fighters are from those communities, and the communities are accustomed to living with these individuals.

Bola is a 25-year-old single woman employed in a bank despite holding a degree in the sciences. She hails from an upper-middle-class family, with her mother working as a lawyer and her father as a contractor. Bola resides far from the epicenter of violence, which allows her to focus on personal matters rather than the immediate threat of insecurity from terrorist violence. I argued that this geographical distance from violence would result in a higher receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized individuals. However, Bola was not receptive to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters into Nigeria. Bola expressed reservations about the program's effectiveness, the government's monitoring plans for reintegrated individuals, and concerns about the community's safety should a reintegrated individual relapse.

Okay, 52 weeks to turn a psychopath into a normal person! That does not make any sense to me. You have killed, maimed people, destroyed properties, and raped because you have a feeling of supremacy going on in your head. You have a mental illness, and you are expected to snap out of that way of life under 52 weeks?

I do not know if reintegrating them into society is smart. What if they relapse? Who is looking after these people when they are living next to my child or my brother? Is there a follow-up? Does somebody know where you are at every point in time? Because there is nature, and then there is nurture. And you said this people do not have formal education, right? So, for 52 weeks, that is roughly one year. So, they are saying they have taught everybody... let us say he is a 25-year-old like me. You have erased years of fear, abandonment, and indoctrination. I am not saying kill them or whatever. The timeframe is ludicrous. I do not think that is possible. – Bola, Lagos Respondent

Regarding the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters into Northern Nigeria, Bola stated –

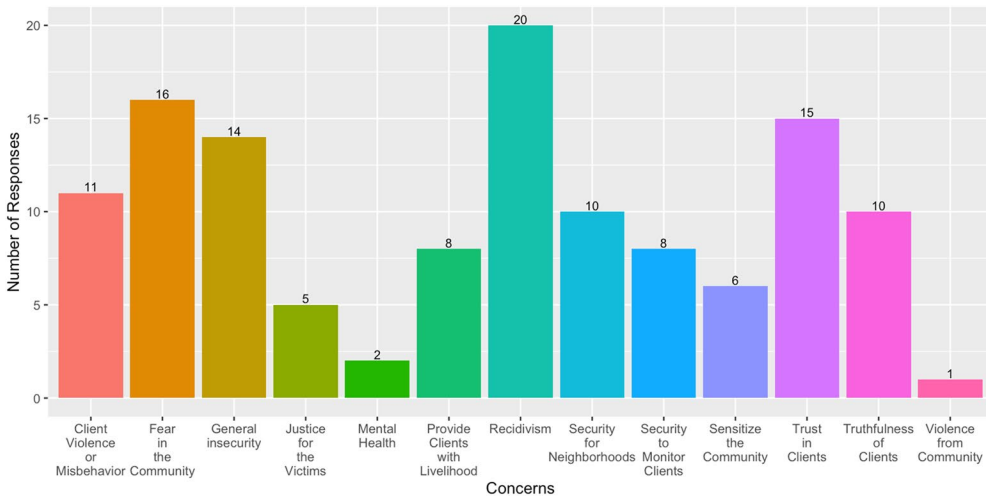


Figure 4. Concerns about reintegration into Nigeria and Northern states by outer community.

As a human, I am wired to be selfish. It hardly matters whether they are in Maiduguri or Magodo...the closer they are, the more tension I have to live with. I am already stressed about the country; why add to it? No, just No! – Bola, Lagos Respondent

The sentiments expressed by Bola are consistent with the broader outlook in the Outer community. Several respondents in this community mentioned the extensive destruction caused by BH in society. However, only a tiny minority, specifically 5 respondents, connected this destruction and feelings of injustice or fairness. Instead, the primary focus among Outer community members was related to recidivism and the trustworthiness of the deradicalized individuals, given their history. The most significant concerns in the Outer community regarding the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters into Nigeria and Northern Nigeria revolved around recidivism, followed closely by general fear and a lack of trust in these individuals (Figure 4).

Despite their geographical distance from the epicenter of violence, individuals in the Outer community are acutely aware of the potential risks posed to their fellow citizens in Northern communities due to media reports of BH attacks. As a result, they express a reluctance to support the reintegration of ex-BH fighters into Northern Nigeria. Their primary concern is the safety of their fellow citizens, and they prefer to prevent potential risks by opposing the reintegration of these individuals. However, they demand that the government ensure security in receiving neighborhoods if the reintegration of ex-BH fighters is unavoidable.

In the Peripheral community, there was lower receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized individuals into Nigeria compared to the Outer community. However, the lack of receptivity in the Peripheral community was still notable, with 55% of respondents indicating they were not receptive to the reintegration (Figure 3). Similarly, regarding the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters into Northern Nigeria, 51% of respondents in the Peripheral community expressed their lack of receptivity (Figure 5). While receptivity was somewhat higher than in the Outer community, it still indicated significant reservations about reintegration. Additionally,

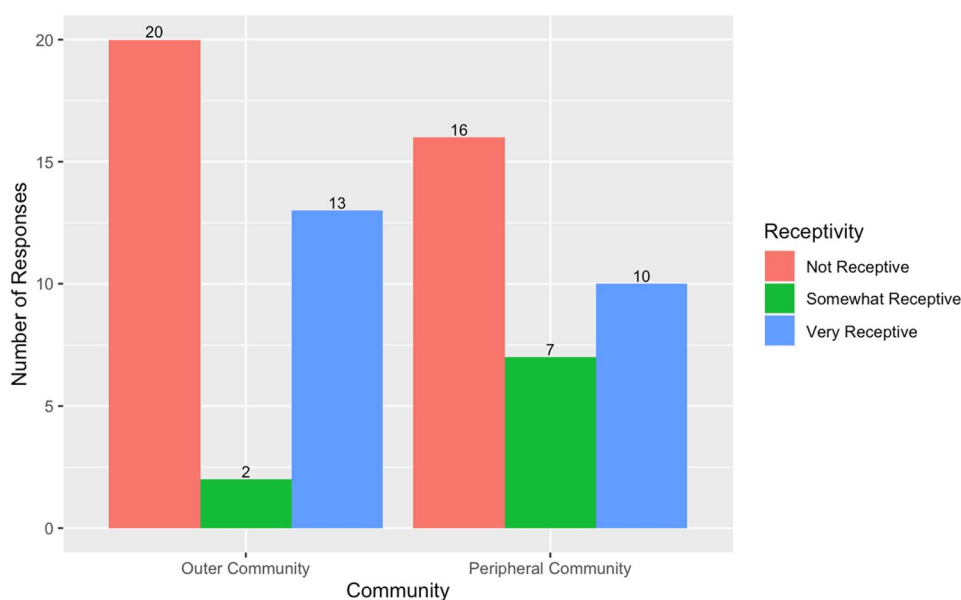


Figure 5. Receptivity to reintegration into Northern Nigeria by outer and peripheral community.

receptivity in the Outer community exhibited more pronounced polarization than in the Peripheral community.

Julia is a 29-year-old single woman, a self-employed entrepreneur with a bachelor's degree. Julia's parents are both civil servants; her mom holds a bachelor's degree, and her dad has a master's degree. Julia's perspective on the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters reflects her awareness of the risks associated with reintegration. I argued that her proximity to the epicenter of violence would negatively influence her receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters due to the potential for increased violence in her community. Julia's lack of receptivity and concern for her community's safety due to heightened fear of violence aligns with the broader sentiment in the Peripheral community about the reintegration of the deradicalized ex-BH fighters.

Scared, scared out of my mind, I have younger ones. I have a nephew and a niece. Even now, I do not let them go out on their own, and then if this happens, that these people are brought back to the system, I would be like...I would have anxiety, and it would be off the roof. Because I mean, just now, um, a couple of months ago, my local community, they were being terrorized, you know, by some of these people.

And I know what they go through even when we visit. It has been going on in our local community for what now? This is our fourth year, and people still have to stay there. So, what do you think they will go through, and now they know that, oh, these people are still somewhere and there is like more of them that went through a program, oh they are good, but then they are back in the system! You know, it will probably make them feel more scared. It would scare me. It would scare me; I would just really be scared. – Julia, Abuja Respondent

Julia's personal experience with violence in her immediate community has profoundly impacted her perception of the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH

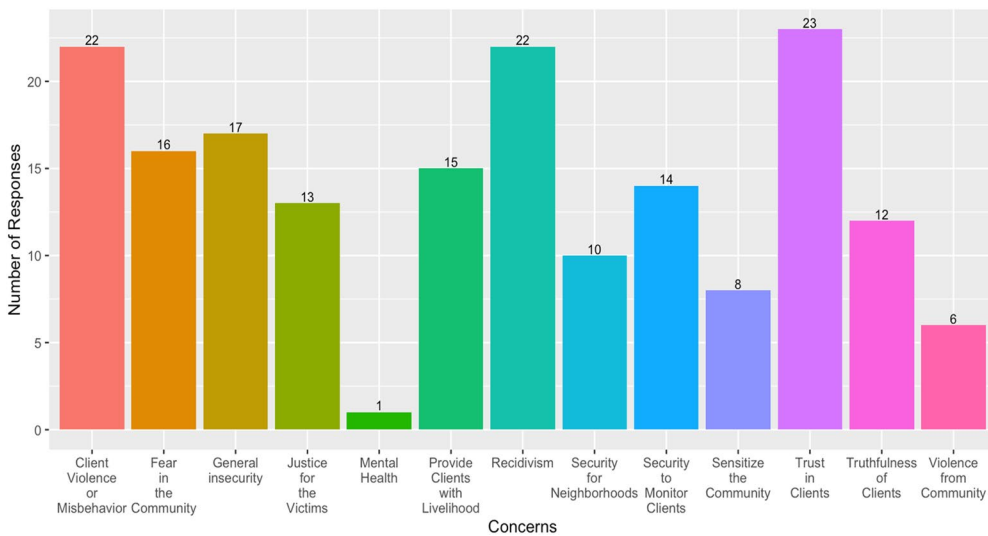


Figure 6. Concerns about reintegration into Nigeria and Northern states by peripheral community.

fighters. Her recollection of the recent incident underscores the real and immediate threat communities in the Peripheral region face. This experience has heightened her concerns about the potential for violence and recidivism among deradicalized individuals. Julia's apprehensions align with the prevailing sentiment in the Peripheral community, where residents' highest concerns were lack of trust in ex-BH fighters, the trustworthiness of ex-BH fighters, and recidivism (Figure 6).

Julia's concerns about reintegrating deradicalized individuals into Northern Nigeria reflect the complex interplay of emotions and practical considerations within the Peripheral community. Her worries about the feelings of injustice and re-traumatization in the core community highlight the Peripheral community's collective trauma from indirectly experiencing violence to the Core community. Additionally, her concerns about recidivism underscore the pervasive fear and mistrust that persist in the face of ongoing security threats.

It is.... oh, wow, Maiduguri. That is scary. That is really scary. The Boko Haram, the children that were taken, then this lady, Leah, this young girl, have not heard about her anymore, you know, and hypothetically, these people that are being brought back into the system are the ones that picked her up. Are they willing to say this is where she is? Are they willing to say this is what happened to her? You know, and you bring them back to the place where it hurts or still hurts for some of them. They go through these things. You know, it is not easy for them because that is the same environment where it all happened. I think a relapse would..... It is really easy for them to just go back. I think because that's where it all happened, they will get triggered and just want to "Oh, I mean, it happened the first time. And now we just know what to do or not to do to be caught. I don't..... they went through the six-month program as well? – Julia, Abuja Respondent

The Peripheral community's strong emphasis on the sense of injustice felt by the Core community regarding reintegration underscores their deep awareness of the

suffering and devastation caused by BH. This awareness contributes to their most significant concerns about trust, recidivism, and the potential for violence upon reintegration. The concerns expressed by the Peripheral community members about the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters reflect their unique perspective, shaped by their proximity to both violence and the Core community. The Peripheral community's calls for enhanced security to monitor the deradicalized individuals reflect their desire to protect their communities from potential harm, recognizing that they could be the next target if deradicalization and reintegration were unsuccessful. These concerns highlight the need for and complexity of designing reintegration programs that must address the needs and perceptions of the Core community and those of neighboring communities directly affected by the violence.

Contrary to my initial argument, the Core community exhibited the highest receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters into both Nigeria and other states in Nigeria. This finding was unexpected, with 69% of respondents specifying that they were very receptive to the reintegration of ex-BH fighters into Nigeria (Figure 3) and 75% of respondents indicating they were very receptive to reintegration into other states in Nigeria (Figure 7). These results suggest that the Core community, despite its direct exposure to violence and trauma, is more willing to accept the reintegration of these ex-BH fighters to Nigeria compared to the Peripheral and Outer communities.

Ahmed is a 51-year-old married man who works as a civil servant and holds a bachelor's degree. His dad was also a civil servant with no college degree, while his mom was a housewife without formal education. Ahmed's receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters differs from the initial assumptions based on proximity to violence. While he resides in a region deeply affected by BH violence, his receptivity is driven by a desire for respite and distance rather than outright

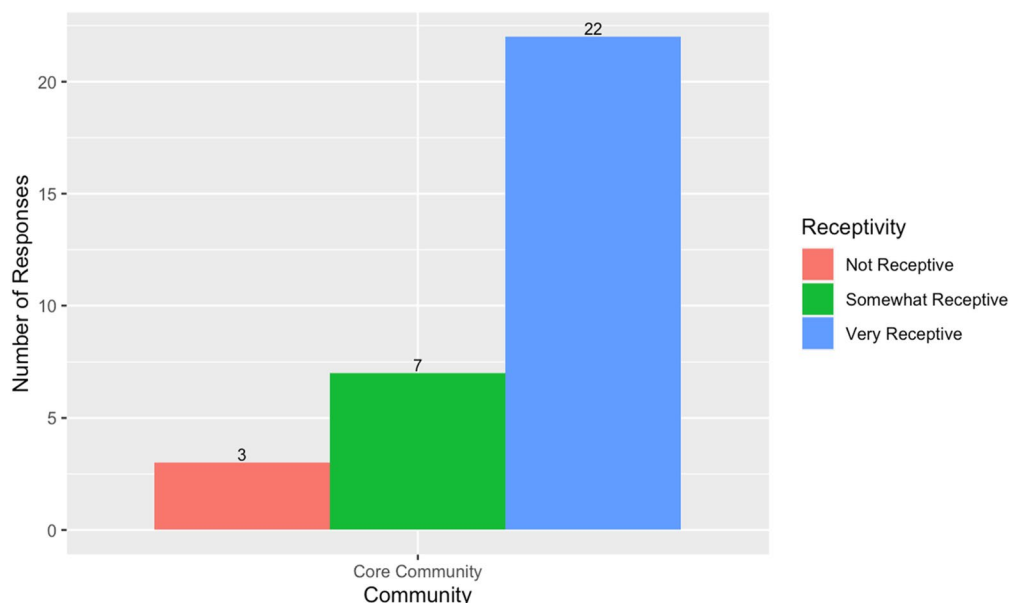


Figure 7. Receptivity to reintegration into other states in Nigeria by Core community.

rejection of reintegration. His perspective highlights an important nuance in community receptivity. In Ahmed's case, the prospect of reintegration occurring farther away from his home state of Borno increases his receptivity because it would provide a sense of safety and distance from potential recidivism or violence. This suggests that community members may have varying motivations and concerns that shape their receptivity to reintegration. Ahmed does not delineate between other states and Nigeria in his response.

That is a very good development. It is even AA in the sense that if you integrate them and take them away from society, from their immediate environment, until the people in their community almost forget what has happened. They may come back after some years to reintegrate. Keeping them in Abuja or anywhere in Lagos or any state. Not in Maiduguri. That is even better, a plus. – Ahmed, Maiduguri Respondent

Ahmed's perspective sheds light on the complex considerations and trade-offs individuals in the Core community may weigh when considering deradicalized ex-BH fighters' reintegration. While proximity to violence has significantly impacted their lives, Ahmed's emphasis on the potential harm and trauma caused to the community members by seeing reintegrated individuals underscores the deep emotional and psychological dimensions of this issue. As highlighted by Ahmed, the Core community's concerns revolve around trust, recidivism, the sincerity of repentance, and fears of potential violence or misbehavior by deradicalized terrorists. These concerns reflect the understandable anxieties that community members may have about the safety and well-being of their community (Figure 8).

I contend that the concerns expressed by the Core community are a direct reflection of their encounters with violence. Having endured the government's inability to shield them from terrorist attacks, their demands do not revolve around safeguarding the communities that may receive ex-BH fighters. Instead, their primary preoccupation

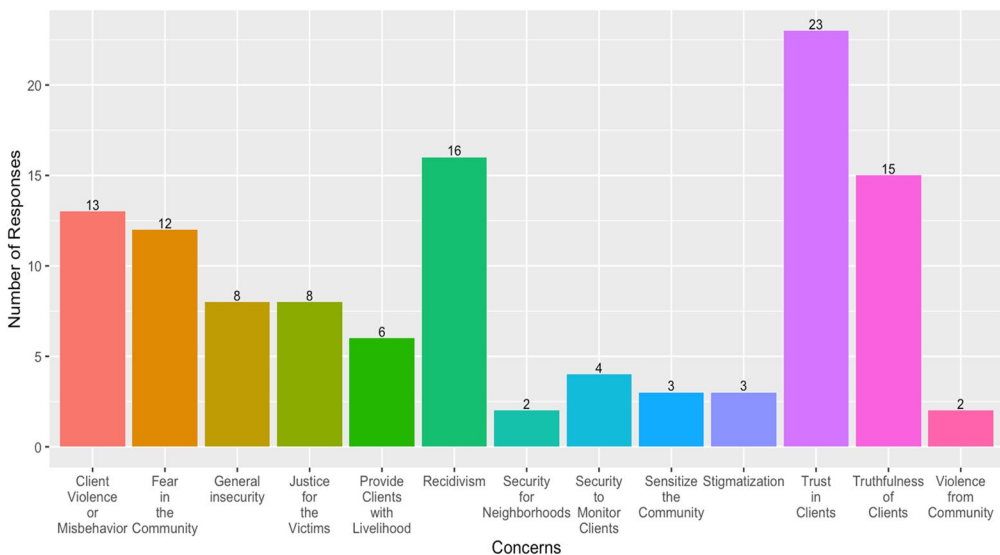


Figure 8. Concerns about reintegration into Nigeria and other states by Core community.

lies squarely with the ex-BH fighters and the potential repercussions of placing trust in them should the deradicalization process prove ineffective. Notably, despite these concerns, the Core community expressed the highest receptivity to reintegration. This could suggest that their desire for respite and distance from potential harm, as articulated by Ahmed, may outweigh their reservations, at least when considering reintegration in other regions or states within Nigeria.

The Core community’s direct exposure to repeated acts of violence and the devastating impact these attacks have had on their lives explain why their primary focus is on the potential risks posed by the reintegrated individuals. Ahmed’s response illustrates the multifaceted nature of community receptivity and the need for reintegration programs to address security concerns and the emotional and psychological well-being of affected communities.

Receptivity into State and Neighborhood

Although I posed distinct questions concerning the willingness to accept reintegrating deradicalized ex-BH fighters into respondents’ respective states and neighborhoods, their responses exhibited coherence across geographical locations. Consequently, I shall consolidate the discussion of both sets of responses. In line with their sentiments concerning reintegration at the national level, respondents from the Outer community consistently demonstrated the lowest degree of receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters into their respective states or neighborhoods. To be precise, a substantial 86% of respondents within the Outer community expressed their non-receptiveness to the idea of reintegrating these individuals into their state or neighborhood (Figure 9).

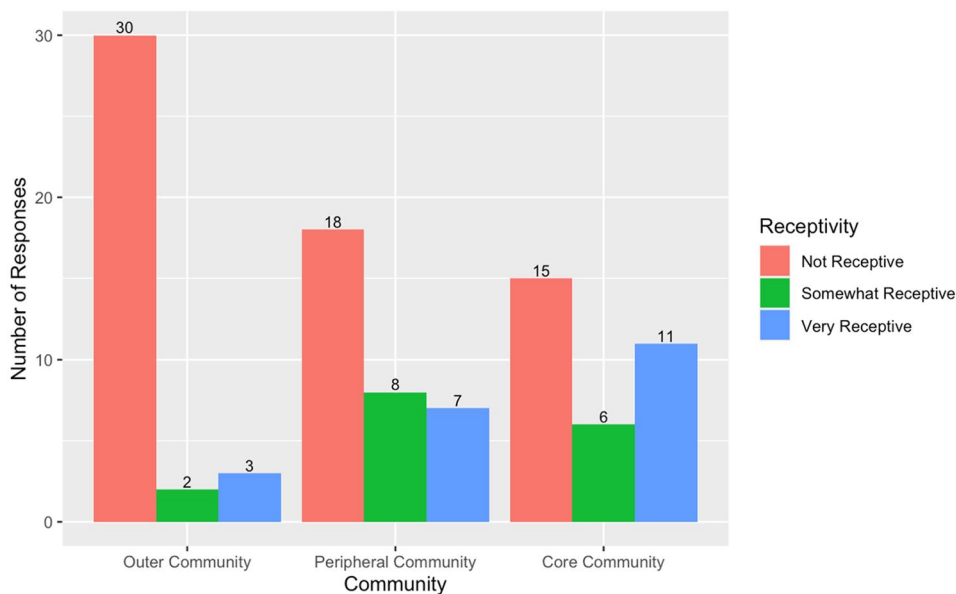


Figure 9. Receptivity to reintegration into state/neighborhood by community.

When queried about the prospect of reintegration into her neighborhood, Bola articulated her intent to promptly relocate, expressing, “I would pack now. One person would leave for one person. I volunteer to leave.” Bola’s response concerning the potential reintegration of deradicalized individuals into Lagos centered on the unique nature of Lagos and the difficulty in distinguishing such individuals from the general populace, thereby exacerbating feelings of fear and insecurity within the state. This sentiment was recurrently echoed by numerous members of the Outer community, wherein apprehension within the community emerged as the primary concern voiced, followed by anxieties related to recidivism, potential violence perpetrated by deradicalized ex-BH fighters, and a prevailing lack of trust in the deradicalized ex-BH fighters.

First of all, keep them where they are now in the ‘bloody program’ place first! There is traffic in Lagos; everybody acts crazy; we do not know the ones that are...like, do you have a tattoo or a helmet on their forehead that says, ‘this one was crazy last year, probably still crazy this year.’ Lagos has how many million people, and you are bringing in certified ‘mad’ No!

I live in Lagos, so no. If it is somewhere that they do not have to mix up with so many people, probably yes. It is Lagos, so no! – Bola, Lagos Respondent

The pronounced emphasis on fear within the Outer community underscores the significance of the geographical buffer that separates them from the Peripheral and Core communities (Figure 10). In the case of the Outer community, the prospect of reintegrating ex-BH fighters into their neighborhood or state shifts their apprehensions from an abstract concern they observe through media reports of violence in core communities to a tangible and immediate sense of vulnerability and peril.

Within the Peripheral community, 55% of respondents conveyed their lack of receptivity toward the potential reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters into their

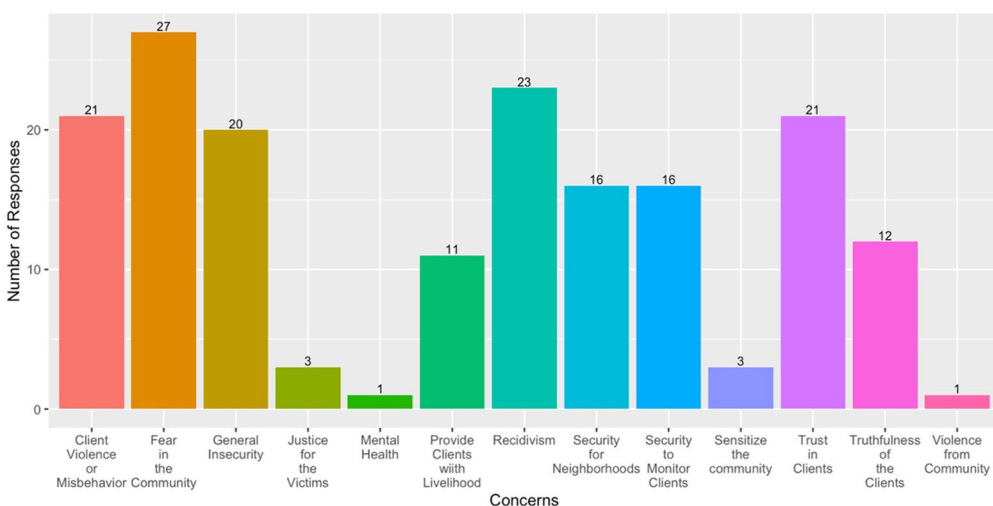


Figure 10. Concerns about reintegration into state/neighborhood by outer community.

neighborhood or state (Figure 9). In contrast, the remaining respondents were comparatively evenly divided between expressing some degree of receptivity and being highly receptive to the reintegration, marking a notable contrast from the Outer community. It is noteworthy that, like Bola, Julia did not differentiate between her specific residential street and the broader context of Abuja when formulating her response regarding receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters. Instead, her responses mirrored those of Bola, centering on apprehensions linked to the reintegrative process. Furthermore, Julia articulated concerns about the program’s efficacy and the potential for recidivism.

I will move out of the neighborhood; I believe people change, right? But for people to change, they obviously have to go through a process. Now, the process will determine if they change for good or bad or worse. So, if the process, which in this context is the program, is 100% vetted, that... And they have this scenario testing, you know, to trigger them to see what their reactions would be, and see if they fall back, or they would go forward, and that is publicized, you know, given as much publicity, I mean, the results given as much as publicity as possible, then maybe if they are released back into the country, or the system, I may be, and that is like a thin may be okay with it. But for the most part, I, Oh, God, I would run; on the plus side, I will just run. – Julia, Abuja Respondent

Unlike the Outer community, those residing in the Peripheral community voiced their most significant concerns as trust in the reintegrated individuals and the potential for violence arising from these ex-BH fighters once reintegrated. These concerns were followed closely by the fear increasing within the community and the prospect of recidivism (Figure 11). The proximity of the Peripheral community members to prior acts of violence directly perpetrated by BH informs the basis of their apprehensions regarding reintegration. In essence, the Peripheral community members have directly experienced acts of violence inflicted by BH. Consequently, their concerns are not rooted in theoretical fear but rather in the tangible possibility of violent actions being

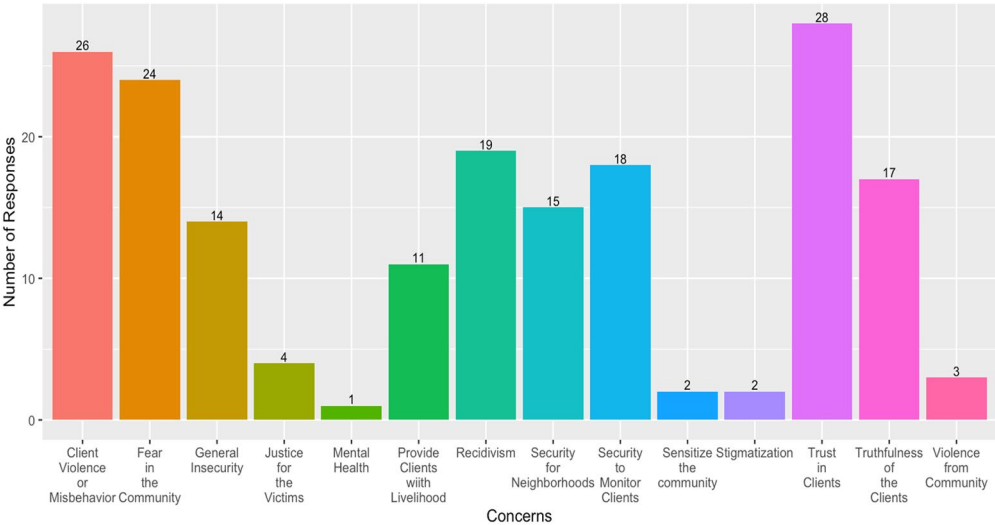


Figure 11. Concerns about reintegration into state/neighborhood by peripheral community.

perpetrated by the returned individuals, which contrasts with the concerns of the Outer community, who have thus far been shielded from such violence and primarily express their anxieties regarding the concept of reintegration in terms of fear.

In the Core community, my initial expectations regarding their receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters were partially affirmed, but only for reintegration to their state and neighborhood and not to the degree I predicted. Contrary to my assumptions, only 50% of the respondents conveyed a lack of receptivity to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters into their community (Figure 9). It is plausible that a portion of those who indicated being “somewhat receptive” may indeed lean towards non-receptivity, thereby intensifying the overall sentiment of reluctance. Furthermore, I contend that the knowledge that the reintegrating individuals were categorized as low-risk offenders played a role in bolstering the receptivity levels among members of the Core community.

Ahmed did not differentiate between his state and neighborhood when responding to the questions regarding his receptivity to the reintegration of the deradicalized ex-BH fighters into his community. Ahmed consistently emphasized throughout his earlier responses the importance of categorizing the surrendered ex-BH fighters into low and high-risk individuals. He believed this categorization is crucial because the high-risk ex-BH fighters have perpetrated such heinous atrocities that they do not deserve to be reintegrated or shown any form of mercy. In Ahmed’s response regarding the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters into Borno or his neighborhood, he expresses a lack of receptivity to the idea. However, he offered a conditional acceptance, suggesting that he may eventually come to terms with their reintegration into the community.

Oh, I will have no blame on them. Although I may, you know, resent it for some time, but still, I will never accuse them of the crime that they have never committed willingly. I will never accuse them of crimes, and I will not mind interacting, communicating, integrating, or making them feel we are together. I will do everything to make them feel at home. Yes, because a crime that was not willingly committed is forgivable. So that is the answer I can give for now. – Ahmed, Maiduguri Respondent

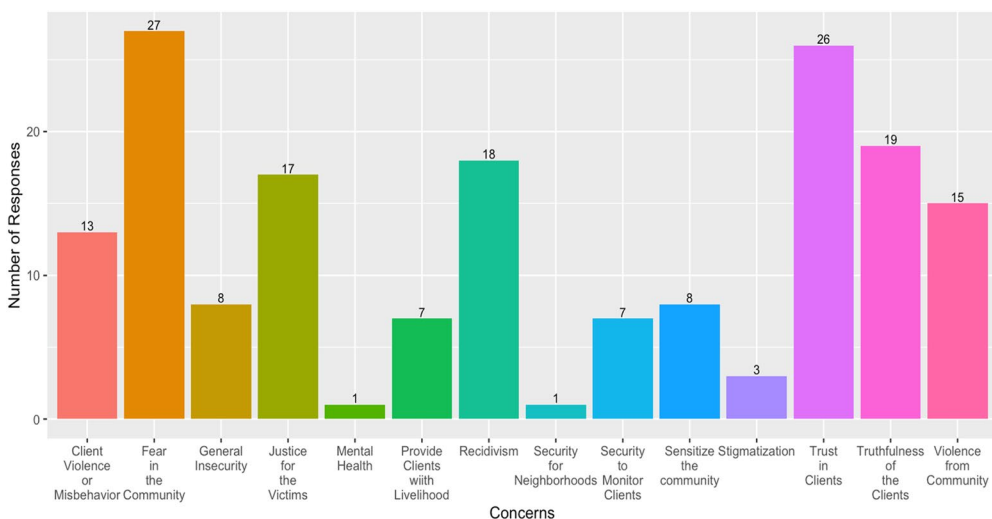


Figure 12. Concerns about reintegration into state/neighborhood by Core community.

In the Core community, the most significant concerns regarding the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters were fear within the community and a lack of trust in these individuals (Figure 12). These concerns were followed by doubts about the sincerity of the ex-BH fighters' repentance, worries about potential recidivism, and reflections on the implications of reintegration for justice for the victims. Interestingly, unlike the Core and Peripheral communities, the Core community members exhibited less concern about the need for enhanced security measures to protect their neighborhood or monitor the activities of the reintegrated ex-BH fighters. Instead, their most profound concern revolved around achieving justice for the victims. This emphasis on justice can be attributed to their status as victims.

Their lack of emphasis on security for the neighborhood or monitoring appears to be deeply rooted in their own traumatic experiences and a profound lack of trust in the government's ability to ensure security and safety. As individuals who have only recently started to experience the benefits of more effective counterterrorism efforts and improved security measures, they are more aware of the dangers posed by the reintegrated individuals. These concerns illustrate the delicate balance that policymakers must strike when designing reintegration programs in regions like Northern Nigeria, where communities are grappling with the legacy of violence.

Conclusion

The findings indicate that all communities are generally unreceptive to the reintegration of deradicalized ex-BH fighters into their states and neighborhoods. However, despite its direct exposure to violence and trauma, the Core community is more willing to accept the reintegration of ex-BH fighters into Nigeria and other states in Nigeria compared to the Peripheral and Outer communities. The Core community is open to reintegrating these ex-BH fighters, provided it does not occur in their immediate neighborhood. In contrast, the Outer and Peripheral communities remain unwavering in their unreceptivity, even beyond their neighborhoods. This discovery—that the Core community exhibited the highest receptivity—is unexpected and contradicts initial assumptions and prior research findings. These surprising results create opportunities for further empirical and theoretical research. Furthermore, they raise the question: in whose backyard should these individuals be reintegrated?

Several factors may contribute to the Core community's higher receptivity toward the reintegration of ex-BH fighters. First, members of the Core community may possess a deeper understanding of the root causes of radicalization and violence, having experienced them firsthand. Respondents in the Core and Peripheral communities consistently raised factors such as poverty, limited job opportunities, food scarcity, inflation, and lack of access to education. This heightened understanding might lead to greater empathy and a willingness to support deradicalization efforts. Furthermore, many respondents in both the Core and Peripheral communities emphasized the critical importance of the Nigerian government addressing these underlying factors before undertaking reintegration efforts.

They expressed concerns that attempting reintegration without first addressing these fundamental issues could worsen the conditions conducive to recidivism. There was a prevailing fear that such an approach might inadvertently incentivize other youths

in the North to join BH, as the consequences of involvement would appear minimal, and they could anticipate eventual reintegration. In essence, the receptivity in the Core community might be driven by a recognition of the complex interplay between radicalization and socioeconomic factors and a realization that effective deradicalization must address these root causes to be successful in the long term.

Secondly, the Core community might recognize the importance of successful reintegration for their region's long-term peace and stability. They may view the reintegration of ex-BH fighters as a necessary step toward preventing further violence and promoting reconciliation within their community. Conversely, the Outer community stands to gain far less from the success of the reintegration process and potentially much more significant losses if the process fails. This perspective aligns with the principles observed in countries participating in DDR programs, where the reintegration of former combatants is considered an essential component of post-conflict recovery. Throughout the three communities, respondents consistently emphasized that ex-BH fighters are Nigerian citizens and could not be reintegrated elsewhere.

Many individuals expressed sentiments about forgiveness and understanding, recognizing that various factors within the country might have motivated ex-BH fighters' involvement in the extremist group. However, there was also a strong and consistent consensus that the government had failed to adequately address several crucial aspects before proceeding with reintegration efforts. These aspects included community rebuilding, victim advocacy, and addressing issues of imprisonment and justice, among others. The communities recognized that these prerequisites were essential to create a conducive environment for successful reintegration and lasting peace.

Lastly, the Core community's familiarity with the deradicalized individuals, who often originate from their community, may contribute to their higher receptivity. Personal relationships and shared cultural and religious backgrounds could foster a sense of trust and a belief in the potential for rehabilitation. Although this research did not specifically aim to measure the impact of religion on receptivity to reintegration, there was an observed higher receptivity among Muslim respondents compared to Christian respondents. However, it is essential to note that the sample composition could influence this observation, as more Christians were interviewed in the Outer and Peripheral Communities, while more Muslims were interviewed in the Core community.

This alignment of religious and proximity receptivity levels suggests that shared religious background might influence the Core community's receptivity levels. However, further research is required to thoroughly examine the impact of religion on receptivity independently of proximity. Additionally, further research is necessary to delve deeper into the factors that shape the Core community's positive attitudes toward reintegration and to gain a more comprehensive understanding of how community dynamics and personal experiences contribute to these perceptions.

The findings from the Core, Peripheral, and Outer communities highlight the complexities and challenges the Nigerian government faces when creating policies for the deradicalization and reintegration of individuals associated with extremist groups like Boko Haram. These challenges include concerns about recidivism, lack of trust, doubts about the truthfulness of deradicalized individuals, and questions about justice for victims and the broader community. Given the receptivity levels observed across these

communities, the Nigerian government must consider a multifaceted approach to address these challenges. Tailoring policies to specific communities and continuously evaluating their effectiveness will be crucial in addressing the complex challenges of deradicalization and reintegration in Nigeria.

This research underscores the critical need for reintegration programs to rebuild trust and confidence within communities across the country and, most importantly, the Core community. Effective communication, transparency, and community involvement in the reintegration process are essential steps toward mitigating these deeply ingrained concerns of community members and fostering a sense of security. This research sheds valuable light on the intricate relationship between proximity to violence, personal experiences, and community receptivity, highlighting the nuanced nature of this complex issue. Understanding these nuances is crucial for designing effective reintegration programs that consider the diverse perspectives of community members.

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